



The Green City Accord

A movement of Mayors
for healthier, cleaner
and liveable cities

Across Europe, we have many cities that are advancing in sustainable urban management, not only because it is environmentally essential but also economically beneficial. Access to more green spaces, improved air quality, less noise and waste, and clean water are vital for our health, for our businesses and for our environment. In this era of climate change, cities must also be prepared for challenges like heat stress and floods.

We acknowledge the crucial role of cities at EU level, and their importance is rising. For many years the European Commission has been supporting them with various urban initiatives. One of them is the Green City Accord, where over 120 mayors across the EU commit to making their cities cleaner and healthier, focusing on five key policy areas: air quality, noise, water management, nature and biodiversity, and waste - circular economy.

I call on European cities to join the Green City Accord. These cities continue to share their stories, learning with other like-minded cities and increasing their transparency and credibility. They also receive visibility and recognition, capacity-building and access to information, helping them transform into better, more livable places for all their citizens."

Jessika Roswall

EU Commissioner for Environment, Water Resilience and a Competitive Circular Economy



What is the Green City Accord?

The [Green City Accord](#) (GCA) is an initiative launched by the European Union in 2020 led by European mayors who aim to make their cities cleaner and healthier. The cities who sign the GCA commit to lead the way in the implementation of the EU environmental law and the European Green Deal initiatives, and to report on their progress. These cities are ready to learn together, inspire others, and enhance the quality of life for all Europeans.

Local governments are at the forefront of the transition to a greener future. Their role is increasingly important at EU level, as recognised by the EU Agenda for Cities. The GCA is a tool to give visibility and provide support in their role in driving meaningful, localised action for sustainability.

Action in five areas

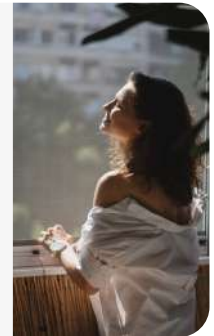
The Green City Accord signatory cities commit to improving their environment and reporting data in **five key areas**:



Air quality:

Cities improve their urban air quality, meeting **EU air quality standards** as soon as possible, aiming to eventually align with the Air Quality Guidelines of the World Health Organization (WHO).

Good news: Europe is **on track**! The number of premature deaths attributable to air pollution has fallen by around 57% between 2005 and 2023, but this still implies more than 180 000 deaths per year, so we must step up efforts.



Water resilience:

GCA cities enhance water quality in urban areas and improve the efficiency of **water infrastructure**, as foreseen in the Zero Pollution Action Plan and in the Water Resilience Strategy.

Europe is warming faster than the global average, with risks to water security increasing and exacerbating water **scarcity, drought and floods**. In fact, water stress now affects 30% of the EU land and 34% of the population.



Nature and biodiversity:

GCA cities protect and enhance urban biodiversity by **increasing green spaces and urban tree canopy**, halting the biodiversity loss and restoring urban ecosystems in line with the EU Nature Restoration Regulation.

Green spaces and healthy ecosystems have **co-benefits** on human health, water resilience, air quality and adaptation to climate change.



Circular economy and waste management:

GCA cities transition towards a circular economy by **enhancing municipal waste management**, reducing waste generation and landfilling, and increasing efforts in reuse, repair and recycling.

The Circular Economy Action Plan and the Clean Industrial Deal aim to reduce waste and extend the life of materials by promoting recycling, reuse and sustainable production, decoupling economic growth from resource use while ensuring the **long-term competitiveness** of the EU.



Noise reduction:

GCA cities are committed to **reducing the share of people chronically disturbed** by noise, complying with the EU Environmental Noise Directive and moving closer to the levels recommended by the WHO.

One in five EU citizens is exposed to noise levels considered harmful to their health. High noise levels can contribute to a wide range of health issues, including cardiovascular, metabolic and mental health diseases.



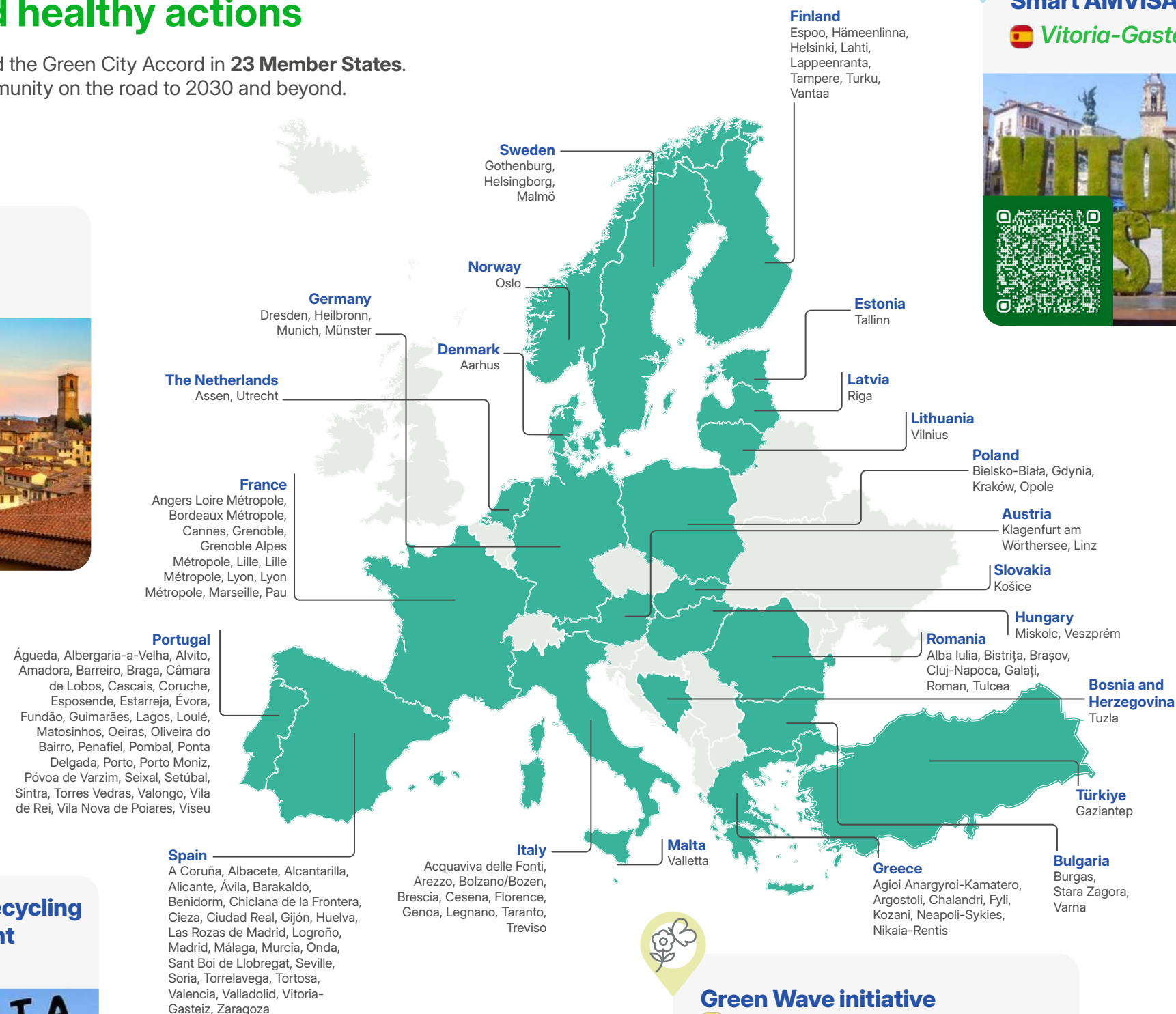
More than 130 cities move forward with green, clean and healthy actions

Since 2020, **132** cities have signed the Green City Accord in **23 Member States**. More cities can join the GCA community on the road to 2030 and beyond.



Airquino

Arezzo



Smart AMVISA 2025 project

Vitoria-Gasteiz



Action Plan for Managing Environmental Noise

Galați



Increasing the material recycling rate in waste management

Lappeenranta



Green Wave initiative

Vilnius



Green City Accord
Discover the Good Practices

Testimonials



"In Matosinhos, we face the climate crisis with ambition and action, placing commitments such as the Green City Accord at the core of our policies to make the city greener, more resilient, and healthier for all our citizens."

Luísa Salgueiro,
Mayor of Matosinhos



"Arezzo's commitment to the Green City Accord, signed on April 30, 2021, is a cornerstone of our strategic vision for a sustainable and prosperous future, supported by the LIFE GreenMe5 project. This initiative is translating into concrete actions: we are actively working to improve air quality, setting an ambitious 2030 target to reduce PM2.5 and PM10 concentration."

Alessandro Ghinelli,
Mayor of Arezzo



"Since adopting its first Agenda 21 in 2001, Lille has placed its commitment to a socially just ecological transition at the heart of its work; a commitment reaffirmed by the ambitious targets it has set in its Lille Climate Plan to reduce greenhouse gas emissions by 45% by 2030 and to adapt the city to climate change. Aware of the climate emergency and convinced of the fundamental role of cities in the ecological transition, the City of Lille joined the Green City Accord in 2020, thereby continuing its efforts alongside its European partners."

Arnaud Deslandes,
Mayor of Lille



"As a supporter organisation, we are leading the project Life GreenMe5 to ease the adoption and implementation of the GCA and we actively encourage our municipalities to join the Accord."

Rocío Méndez,
European Affairs policy officer at the Federation of Municipalities of the Region of Murcia

Commitments based on data

The signatories of the Green City Accord report of their progress towards reaching the objectives set for 2030. The first [Green City Accord report](#) highlights the starting points, commitments and objectives of the signatory cities from 2020 to 2023 and is continuously updated.

Trends and ambitions:

• Air quality

Most reporting cities meet EU air-quality standards, and about 90% are on track. Many are starting to align with the stricter WHO guidelines, expanding clean mobility and reducing emissions from transport and heating.

• Water resilience

Cities are upgrading wastewater treatment, repairing networks, and using nature-based solutions for stormwater. About half of them comply with EU wastewater rules and all are committed to fully comply, and a similar share has targets to reduce domestic water use, already using slightly less than the EU average per person.

• Nature and biodiversity

GCA cities are restoring wetlands, greening streets and safeguarding local habitats. On average, cities report tree coverage above the EU-wide baseline, while several are rapidly creating new parks, pocket forests and green corridors. Yet only about one in five cities currently has a level of protected land comparable to the EU average, showing a need for continued restoration efforts.

• Circular economy and waste

Cities are reducing waste, improving management, and cutting landfill use. Around 75% generate less municipal waste than the EU average. Most have waste-reduction targets and are supporting repair hubs, separate collection, and circular enterprises.

• Noise

Cities are reducing chronic noise, following the EU Noise Directive, and moving towards the WHO guidelines. About 25% report that over half of residents still face excessive nighttime noise. Most monitor noise levels, with many below EU averages, and are creating quiet zones, redesigning traffic, and promoting low-noise mobility.



A network of Green Cities to showcase, learn and exchange

The **Green City Accord** signatories join a network of like-minded cities who drive the transition towards a cleaner, healthier, resilient and more competitive Europe. The cities gain visibility, increase their transparency, accountability and credibility. The cities participate in events, exchanges of best practices and capacity-building activities, receive tailored guidance and support, and are permanently updated about **EU initiatives**, calls and funding opportunities.

The Green City Accord is a solid foundation to run for the **European Green Capital** or **European Green Leaf awards**. The European Green Cities network gathers awarded cities and finalists and **Green City Accord signatories**.

*Pictures: Network Meeting, Vilnius (January 2025),
Speakers at the Green City Accord Commitment Ceremony, in Vilnius, January 2025*



How can my city join?

Signatories: EU cities with a population of over 20 000 inhabitants, including metropolitan areas and urban agglomerations, are eligible to sign the **Green City Accord**.

Supporters: The supporters mobilise resources, encourage the cities to sign the **Green City Accord**, and assist them to implement the actions and achieve the environmental goals of this initiative. National, regional and provincial authorities, networks and associations of cities, thematic agencies, international organisations, research institutions, think tanks and civil society organisations can become supporters of the **Green City Accord**. Other entities (e.g. associations of service providers) can be admitted as supporters on a case-by-case basis.

Associated cities and supporters: Cities from non-EU Member States* can commit to the **Green City Accord** goals and objectives and become associated cities, taking part in the network activities and events. Similarly, organisations from these countries can be associated supporters.

*Members of the European Economic Area, EU candidate countries and potential candidates. These are: Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Iceland, Georgia, Liechtenstein, Moldova, Montenegro, North Macedonia, Norway, Serbia, Türkiye and Ukraine.

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